

accurately hit the ball with some power and place it where I wanted. Once I began competing against more skilled players, I quickly learned I was on the peak of *Mount Stupid*. I was regularly getting demolished by players I thought I was better than. I spent a lot of time wandering in the *Valley of Despair*.

Out of frustration, I started working with a coach. He put me on the *Slope of Enlightenment* and helped me improve the mechanics of my swing. Previously, my forehands were bouncing up too high, right into the sweet spot of any opponent's swing. A better swing with more topspin cut down on those fat returns. My court positioning and approach to the ball were also poor; my serve was soft, and my backhand (my best swing) was underutilized. I am a much better player today, in large part because I know *just how mediocre I am*. I have learned to play within my own ability and skill level, avoiding unforced errors and letting the other person beat themselves. The *Plateau of Sustainability* is a never-ending embrace of improvement and learning.

“Does anyone really know what Dunning-Kruger actually is?” has a recursive character. As you might expect, those who don't study it don't truly understand it. It reminds me of *Fight Club*, the 1999 film starring Brad Pitt and Edward Norton: The first rule of Dunning-Kruger Club is that you do not know you are in Dunning-Kruger Club...³⁷⁴



One of the challenges of being knowledgeable about cognitive issues is the Bias Blind Spot. We all have the same biases as everyone else—but we are mostly unaware of them. As I was going through my prior research for this book, I couldn't help but notice—repeatedly—how often I succumbed to the very errors I was writing about.

In discussing his blind spots, Kahneman referenced his own biases, saying “I certainly do not claim to be immune from them. I suffer from all of them.”³⁷⁵